Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for

NIH/NLM SPARK dbGaP Challenge

List of Questions

Click a question below to go directly to its answer. In Microsoft Word, hold Ctrl (Cmd on a Mac) and click. Use "Back to List of Questions" after each answer to return here.

1. Who can participate? Can non-U.S. citizens, non-permanent residents, or federal employees take part?
2. How do I know if my project is within the scope of this Challenge?
3. Is registration required, and how do I register?
4. Should I register as an individual, team, or entity?
5. Are there team size limits, can team members change, and will there be networking sessions?
6. How and when do I submit my entry?
7. As part of the evaluation, will there be subject matter experts as reviewers?
8. How are cash prizes paid, can they be split, and are there restrictions on how they can be used?
9. Where can I direct any questions?

Challenge FAQs

1. **Who can participate? Can non-U.S. citizens, non-permanent residents, or federal employees take part?**

   Non-U.S. citizens and non-permanent residents can participate as a member of a team that otherwise satisfies the eligibility criteria. They are not eligible to win a monetary prize (in whole or in part), but their participation as part of a winning team may be recognized when the results are announced.

   Federal employees acting within the scope of their employment, and HHS employees acting in their personal capacity, are not eligible. Employees of other federal agencies should consult their agency ethics official to determine whether federal ethics rules limit or prohibit accepting a prize. See the eligibility rules on the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page for full details.

   For additional information, please consult the SPARK dbGaP Challenge pages:

- https://www.nih.gov/challenges/semantic-precision-ai-retrieval-knowledge-spark-dbgap-challenge – **General information for the NIH/NLM SPARK dbGaP Challenge**
- https://repository.niddk.nih.gov/data-challenge/challenges/67 – **SPARK dbGaP — Task 1: Semantic Variable Normalization and Ontological Alignment**
- https://repository.niddk.nih.gov/data-challenge/challenges/100 – **SPARK dbGaP — Task 2: Conversational Cohort Feasibility & Privacy-Preserving Discovery**

Back to List of Questions

2. **How do I know if my project is within the scope of this Challenge?**

   Please read the challenge description on the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page.

   Back to List of Questions

3. **Is registration required, and how do I register?**

   Yes. All participants must register through the Challenge Management Platform, in accordance with the rules on the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page. You can go directly to the Task 1 or Task 2 page and select "Register."

   You do not need an eRA Commons account. On the RAS sign-in page, choose either eRA Commons or Login.gov; an institutional eRA Commons ID is not required.

   Back to List of Questions

4. **Should I register as an individual, team, or entity?**

   Choose the category that best reflects the contributors to your submission. Each category has different eligibility requirements for receiving a cash prize, so please review them, along with any restrictions your employer may place on your participation. The registration categories and prize eligibility requirements are described in the rules on the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page.

   Back to List of Questions

5. **Are there team size limits, can team members change, and will there be networking sessions?**

   There is no minimum or maximum team size; individuals and teams of any size are eligible to compete. Teams can change members as needed, provided any new members meet the eligibility criteria. This Challenge will not hold networking events to help form teams; individuals are encouraged to reach out to anyone they feel has the expertise needed to form a successful team. For more information, see the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page.

Back to List of Questions

6. **How and when do I submit my entry?**

   All entries are submitted through the Challenge Management Platform (Task 1 or Task 2). Submission happens in two stages:

   - System upload: all system development must be completed, and the final system(s) frozen, date-stamped, and uploaded by the system upload deadline. No changes are permitted after this deadline.
   - Evaluation submission: after the evaluation dataset is released, participants use their frozen system(s) to generate responses to the evaluation test cases and upload them by the evaluation submission deadline.

   Late submissions will not be accepted. All key dates and deadlines are listed on the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page. Please check it regularly for any updates.

Back to List of Questions

7. **As part of the evaluation, will there be subject matter experts as reviewers?**

   Yes. Reviewers will be selected based on their relevant expertise in the field. Subject matter experts (SMEs) may be engaged to develop Challenge questions and reference responses, assess the quality, accuracy, relevance, and completeness of submitted responses, and support other aspects of the evaluation, as applicable to the Challenge. Reviewers will follow the evaluation criteria and procedures established for the Challenge. For more information, see the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page.

Back to List of Questions

8. **How are cash prizes paid, can they be split, and are there restrictions on how they can be used?**

   Winners will be contacted by program officials with instructions. Prizes are paid in full to the winning individual, team leader, or entity. For teams, the team leader receives the full prize and is solely responsible for dividing it among team members; NIH will not arbitrate or resolve matters among team members.

   For rules on the use and treatment of prize funds, see Participation Rule 1 in the Participation Rules section of the SPARK dbGaP Challenge page. Payment and tax details are also described in the rules. Entities are encouraged, but not required, to obtain a free Unique Entity ID (UEI) via SAM.gov to speed up prize payment.

Back to List of Questions

9. **Where can I direct any questions?**

Before submitting a question about the SPARK dbGaP Challenge, participants or potential participants should:

1. **Review the Challenge website and documentation for information about the Challenge objectives, eligibility requirements, submission process, evaluation criteria, timelines, and technical requirements.**
2. **Review the Participation Rules and FAQs to determine whether your question has already been addressed.**
3. **Check the Challenge platform for the latest announcements, updates, and participant guidance.**
4. **Review any applicable technical documentation before submitting questions related to data access, submission formats, APIs, or other technical requirements.**
5. **Provide sufficient context when submitting a question that is not addressed in the available materials. Include the relevant Challenge task or phase and, where applicable, the specific requirement, error message, or issue you encountered.**

Questions that are not addressed in the available Challenge materials may be directed to:

- NLMSPRKCHLG_DBGAP@mail.nih.gov

Back to List of Questions